

Computing On The Go

The notebook is no longer a rare commodity, and buying one has never been easier. To simplify your choice, we looked at some of the best solutions out there...

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For many, a laptop is something to show off—flash an expensive one at an airport or at the odd boardroom discussion and you're bound to get attention.

Such people belong to a soon-to-be extinct species. Most people who own a laptop today will be the first to tell you that it was functionality, utility and convenience that made them go for a notebook, rather than style, panache or even sex appeal.

The most obvious class of people to benefit from notebooks are, of course, the business class. As an owner of a company, you have to be constantly informed of

changes both within and outside your organisation.

What about the average BE or MBA student, who attends lectures during the day, studies during the night, and works on projects in between? You'll need something to take down quick notes, quick access to the Internet to verify facts and do some research. You'll also probably want to unwind to a movie, or listen to some music while you work on your project. Then you may need to work on a report, during lunch hour.

For all of the above, a notebook would be a necessity. Like caffeine, something that is needed to jump start one's day, or at the least see them through it. So a luxury no more, a notebook has even gone so far as replacing a desktop in some homes, simply because, the fam-

ily would rather be more flexible, and nobody has accused desktops of being that...

Traditionally, notebooks have lacked just two things—usability, which is important to everyone—and performance, which is important to most people. These comparisons are made with respect to a desktop PC, which in general, is more powerful, more general purpose, more comfortable and ergonomic to use, and can perform a few tasks beyond most laptops. While this chasm of shortcomings between notebooks and desktops still exists, (and may always exist), laptops today are more powerful processing machines than their predecessors that are just a year old.

We've tested 36 notebooks across all spheres of usage, and from all possible manufacturers. No matter what your need, if you're shopping for a laptop solution you are going to find one in the following pages.

DESKTOP REPLACEMENTS Stable Beings

Sony Vaio VGN-AR69GU

This 17-inch behemoth is definitely not meant to keep on your lap, unless you have a very large lap indeed, or need to keep it warm! What this is, however, is a desktop replacement and a powerful and good looking one at that. While the build, fit and finish are excellent, the AR-69GU feels solid to hold, you get the feeling that a device so large defeats the purpose of being a notebook. The screen is gorgeous and crisp, and the keypad wonderfully spaced out—a pity though, that the multimedia buttons are very clicky and tacky. The touchpad is also sensitive and imparts just the right amount of feedback. With 3 GB of system memory and a 256 MB GeForce 8600GT under the hood, you can expect this giant to be no slouch.

There's a fully functional Windows MCE remote bundled with this thing, and Sony also provides S-Video and TV antenna jacks, in addition to an HDMI port. Incidentally, the 17-inch screen does 1920x1200 pixels, so native 1080p should be a wonderful experience. This notebook's entertainment genes are wonderfully evident even before switching it on. You'll find the shortcut keys very utili-

tarian—our only gripe being the typically soft Vaio keypads, which lack key feedback—they're too soft. With two 250 GB hard drives on board and a DVD Writer-cum-Blu-ray drive, this notebook has a configuration that should stand the test of time...at least for another couple of years.

We really enjoyed this notebook as far as home entertainment is concerned. It's not for the discerning gamer, but it does most tasks with ease, while retaining functionality as a fully remote-controllable desktop replacement. At Rs 1,69,900, the largest Vaio in this test is very expensive. But that's in keeping

